



The Category Design Canvas

Stop competing in someone else's category. Name your own.

90 minutes

Strategy • Positioning • Founders

A3 landscape

v1 • 2026

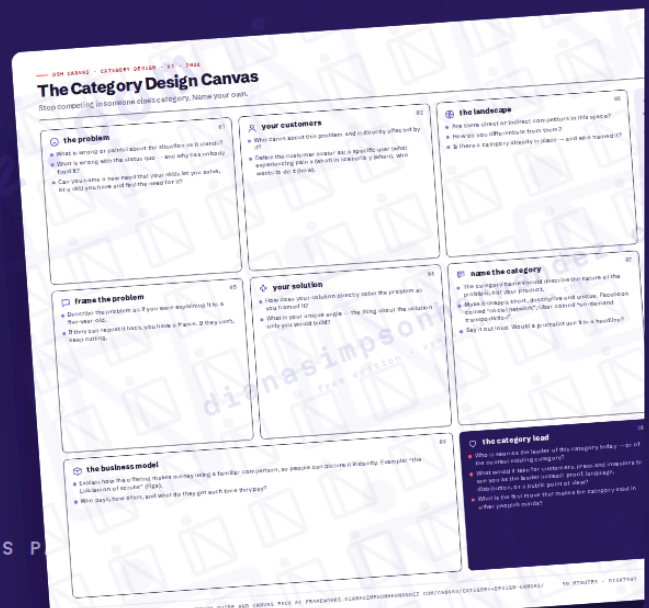
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Free A3 PDF + quick guide

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— WHAT IT IS

What this canvas does

Category design is the discipline of creating and naming the market you want to win, rather than fighting for share of one that already has a leader. The canvas forces a specific sequence: understand the problem and the person before you touch the solution, take a public point of view before you take a name, and prove you can defend the category before you announce it.

— WHEN TO USE IT

- You are launching something genuinely new and the existing labels make it sound like a cheaper version of an incumbent.
- You keep losing deals on price, which usually means you are being compared inside someone else's category.
- Investors or partners describe your company in words you would never choose.

— WHO IT IS FOR

Founders and product leads positioning a new product, or repositioning one that is losing on price. 90 minutes with three to eight people.

— BOX BY BOX

The short version

01 • THE PROBLEM

Write the pain in the customer's words, not yours. Then write what is wrong with how it is handled today.

03 • THE LANDSCAPE

List the direct and indirect alternatives, including doing nothing. Name the category they sit in and who is credited with it.

05 • FRAME THE PROBLEM

Explain it to a five-year-old. Read it aloud to someone outside your industry and ask them to repeat it.

07 • NAME THE CATEGORY

Draft five names. Each must describe the problem space, not the product. Test each in a fake headline.

09 • THE BUSINESS MODEL

Use a familiar comparison so anyone can picture how you make money, then state who pays, how often, and for what.

02 • YOUR CUSTOMERS

Fill the avatar sentence: who, what pain, when, and what they want to do instead. One person, not a segment.

04 • YOUR POINT OF VIEW

State the belief the incumbents don't hold, the old way versus the new way, and what changed in the world to make the new way possible now.

06 • YOUR SOLUTION

Now, and only now, describe the solution — as the direct answer to the frame, and with the angle only you would take.

08 • YOUR UNFAIR ADVANTAGE

List what you have that a well-funded competitor would still lack after a year: data, distribution, method, licence, domain knowledge.

10 • THE CATEGORY LEAD

Name who is seen as the leader today, what it would take to displace them in the minds of customers and press, and the first public move that makes your category exist.

The Canvas Pack (£49) has the full walkthrough for every canvas — what good looks like for each box, a worked example, the agenda and the mistakes — plus clean A3 PDFs and 4K PNGs.
frameworks.dianasimpsonhernandez.com/canvas/